SpeechGeek



Season Ten: Winter 2013

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Looking back, 2012 has been an action-packed year. *The Avengers* and *The Dark Knight* muscled their way into theaters and rescued lagging box office sales. Strength and agility also helped U.S. Olympians like Gabby Douglas bring home the gold. And chances are—if you're reading this—the Mayan calendar is being filed away with Y2K in the "Unnecessary End-of-the-Year Worries" box.

While everyone is trying to remember to write the right year, you've got plenty of other things keeping you busy. We're in the full swing of tournament season with district, state, and even national tournaments on the horizon. Your brain is chock full of memorized pieces, tournament planning to-do lists, and polishing pieces after reading ballots. The last thing you need to remember is to go out searching for new literature. That's why we went ahead and published five new pieces in addition to this letter. What a bargain!

Here's hoping that 2013 brings you good fortune, great ballots, and unforgettable performances!

Corey Alderdice
Publisher



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Content

by Wes Tantz

(*While smoking cigarette, Marion should be making subtle touches to her stomach because she is with child—but it shouldn't be obvious.)*

MARION. (*reading from book*) "Poets are always taking the weather so seriously. They are always sticking their emotions in things that have no feelings."

When I first started writing, I used to hail these gaudy beings as proof for why I was the way I was or why I did the things I did. After months of reading, re-reading, and a descent into nihilism, I just realized I was a woman who was too busy rotating on my axis to focus on the planets and shooting stars around me.

(*reading from book)* "All cowardice comes from not loving or not loving well."

Then again, maybe that's what it is. All of these people are too much on their axis, too. Or too busy sucking the life out of anything that remained nameless. You know, I never understood why love was such a holy topic. It's not all that, let me tell you. Let me tell you a story.

I knew a girl once who fell so in love with a boy. She fell and fell and fell and fell so far past the Earth that she spiraled out into the universe. She was carried by all these feelings that seemed warm and comforting, but once thrown into space, they were nothing. She floated with the dust and fell and fell and came to a black hole. There, she was sucked inside, and what did she find? Well, a party! There was booze, there was coke, there were people, and she danced until the stars shook and fell to her feet. There was John Lennon, Albert Einstein, and Ernest Hemingway. And you'll never believe who was hosting the party. Jesus H. Christ himself! Dressed in a pink suit, all Gatsby-like. So cool and so clique, waiting on his Daisy to float on by…(*laughs*). Hmm. You know that's why people never return from black holes. It's one endless party. I mean who'd want to? She sent me a postcard once. It was real nice. Jesus is a handsome looking fellow let me tell you. (*She laughs and continues to smoke.*)

Forever As the Stars

by E. J. Williams

(*As he is painting, he sings.*)

JOHN. *Unforgettable, that's what you are;*
Unforgettable, though near or far;
Like a song of love that clings to me,
How the thought of you does things to me.

(*He chuckles and wipes brow. He is lost in thought for a moment.*) Nat King Cole? Circa 1964? Judging by the looks on your faces and the pep in your step, I'm sure that was before your time. Can't blame you. Nat was before my time, too, but Parker loved him. He could play every song. See, Parker was a painter by day but a pianist by night. My pianist, I used to call him. We made a good team, Parker and I. He was the music, and I was the voice.

To be truthful, that's how we met. It was one of those nights where you notice the stars—like they've suddenly forgotten how to submit to the city lights and are just up in the sky, twinkling with a kind of fury that makes you take notice. I remember getting out of my car at the jazz bar, looking up into the fiercely lit sky, and whispering, "Tonight, John, regardless of what's happened prior to this moment, tonight is going to be unforgettable." And would you know, that's what he was playing right when I walked through the door. Unforgettable. It's one of ole Nat King Cole's most beautiful songs, in my opinion.

Now, it had been a horrible night 'til that point, 'til I saw those stars. I'd had a blind date earlier—a friend-of-a-friend. Well, more of a friend-of-a-friend-of-an-old-lover, but who could've guessed it'd be as bad as it was. The man…oh what was his name? Leonard… Liam… Something with an "L." It doesn't matter. He comes into the restaurant, sits down, and spends half an hour in tears. Not he wasn't ready to date, but the friend-of-a-friend-of-an-old-lover said that it would be good for him. Anyway, I spend a half hour there—wiping up this man's tears—and headed home discouraged and loathing my ex. You know, I almost did go home that night. But something told me "jazz." I needed to drown my sorrows with a cocktail and some jazz.

So there I was, walking through the doors of Blue Smoke, the premier hole-in-the-wall jazz club of Alabaster, Alabama. And there he was sitting at his piano, eyes closed and focused solely on the

music. His face, so gentle yet passionate, his hands—the way they danced across the keys. Unforgettable, indeed.

Now with my luck so far that night, I wasn't dare going to approach that beautiful man. My plan was to admire from afar. But after three cocktails and a final good luck shot, I was traipsing toward the piano with the biggest grin on my face. Right as I got up to him, the song changed to "L-O-V-E." And without a single bit of hesitation, I belted that song out for the whole club to hear. By the end, he was smiling, watching me right along with the whole rest of the place. I even got a standing ovation.

It was the last song of the night, and he was the last man I'd love in my whole life. I knew from the moment I walked in.

I'd had a bit too much to drink. Parker offered to save this damsel in distress by asking if I'd like a ride. We laughed the whole way back to my place. I invited him inside, but he respectfully declined. I was mortified, but I guess he could sense my embarrassment. He leaned in really close, kissed me on the cheek, told me that my hair looked like honey, and said that I had the voice of an angel.

I laughed, looked right into his beautiful brown eyes, and said, "You're wrong. My hair *is* honey, Parker. And I don't have the voice of an angel, I have the voice of a god."

That was our first kiss. The first kiss melted into the second and third. The first kiss was followed by a thousand beautiful kisses, each more tender and loving than the last.

He asked me to marry him on our third date. I laughed and said that if he could find the priest who would marry us, I'd find the dress. Don't look at me like that, son, I was just kidding around. But he sure wasn't. I'd never seen a more determined look in any man's eye, and I doubt I ever will again. He gave me this ring. Told me it was a symbol--a symbol of trust, of love and of devotion—that's why it's round. No end in sight. It had belonged to his great-grandfather, who had stayed married to the same woman for nearly eighty years. That's what he wanted with me, he said. Eighty years to love me, take care of me, and be my forever. That's what he said—that he wanted to be my forever. We married that night under an old willow tree in his yard. I moved into his house the next day.

You know, time is a funny thing in how it seems to fold in on itself at will. Something can seem forever then be gone before you realize

how incredible it was when it was here.

Sorry for getting serious on you here. It's just… I get like that when I paint sometimes. Now, I know painting was Parker's thing, and he was incredible at what he did. Which is why I'm… I'm trying to finish this. For him.

He was painting this when I told him. I walked into his studio and there he was, his paintbrush dancing across the canvas with a fiery passion I can't even describe. I asked him to set down the paintbrush. He laughed, pulled me over and asked me to look at what he was painting. It was us, Parker and myself, only it was more abstract than I'm making it sound. It was us but we were sitting inside of this ring, hand-in-hand. The only thing he hadn't finished was the sky. I could feel the tears welling up in my eyes as I stared into his dream of forever. A forever I couldn't give him.

It was an accident. We'd been fighting a lot about little things—about laundry, dishes, bills, the things people who live together fight about. I'd gone out, had one too many cocktails… and… (*looks into the painting, singing*)

E is even more than anyone that you adore…

I'm sorry, Parker. I should've used protection. No, no, that's not what I mean. No, I should have stayed home with you. Not gone out. Not drowned my tears in cocktails. I should have cuddled up to you that night and cried myself to sleep then let you wipe away my tears and tell me that it's okay, that we will be okay—that we were both wrong. Would we have been? Okay? Would we have made it eighty years, Parker?

You seemed to think so. You always seemed to think everything was going to be fine. There was never any doubt. You made me feel guilty, do you know that? For thinking, for feeling like maybe there wasn't such a thing as forever. Failing you terrified me, Parker. In the end, that's exactly what I did. I failed you. So here I sit, missing you. Finishing this damn painting even though I don't have a half of the talent you did with a brush, but it deserved to be finished. You deserved forever. I'm so sorry that I took it away from you.

(*bittersweet laugh, continues painting*) You know, I told Parker that I had the voice of a god. Well, I was wrong. Gods can make things happen—change things and make things better. He told me I had the voice of an angel, but angels can protect and watch over people. I have the voice of a man. Just…a man.

But Parker, he was something more. Even after being diagnosed, Parker was like one of those stars from the night I met him, twinkling with a kind of brilliant fury that made you take notice. It was like he forgot that AIDS meant he was supposed to submit to his impending death. He played the piano every night, but he never picked up this paintbrush again. Not once. Never finished the sky. I found this the afternoon of the funeral. I went into his studio to cry it out, and there it was, just as it had been the day I told him we were HIV positive. There we were, inside of that ring, a promise, a symbol of forever.

Now I know you probably wanted it to be daylight, Parker, but I can't help but to want to see those stars with you again. And so, I'm painting a night sky. A sky that goes on forever with a million twinkling stars, each more dazzling than the last, each forgetting to submit to the bright lights below. When I see you again, my pianist, I'll sing to you until forever. You'll be my music, and I'll be your voice. We'll shine, together, Parker, bright and fierce as these stars.

(*painting, singing*)

Unforgettable in every way,
And forever more that's how you'll stay;
That's why darling it's incredible,
That someone so unforgettable,
Thinks that I am unforgettable, too.